

Other than outrage

Restrictions on women cannot be the answer to unsafe public spaces

There is a sickening sense of *dējā vu* in last month's headlines of sexual assaults against women and children. In the national capital alone, the gang-rape of a 17-year-old girl in Astha Kunj Park by three men posing as police personnel, the gang-rape and murder of a 16-year-old in Swaroop Nagar, and the gang-rape of another 17-year old on a sleeper bus travelling from Greater Noida to Delhi have each shocked the nation briefly before giving way to a numb outrage. Little seems to have changed in the 14 years since the candlelight marches and commissions after the Nirbhaya case unleashed a slew of new schemes, laws and funds that vowed to protect women and girls from sexual violence, especially in public spaces. The latest report of the National Crime Records Bureau shows an 80% surge in crimes against women since Nirbhaya, from 2.4 lakh in 2012 to 4.4 lakh in 2024. Some of this can be attributed to higher reporting of crimes, facilitated by those new laws and schemes, but that is not sufficient to account for the vast number of them. In 2024, more than 50 crimes against women were reported every hour, with the highest rate of such crimes seen in the metro cities of Jaipur, Indore, Lucknow, and Delhi.

The government has listed a slew of initiatives meant to deal with the problem, from the Safe City project to Mission Shakti, from a women's helpline and emergency response support system to one-stop centres for survivors of sexual violence and fast-track courts, many of which have been financed through the Nirbhaya Fund. The recent crimes, however, put a question mark on the implementation of such schemes. A safe city cannot be created simply by installing lighting and CCTV cameras, if they are not functional, monitored, and connected to a response system. Police patrols and emergency numbers matter only if they result in prompt intervention from trained and sensitised personnel. It is important to move from scheme-based policing to preventive, and outcome-based policing, with public audits of vulnerable locations with deadlines and accountability to rectify deficiencies. The justice system must address the enormous backlog of cases; the promise of speedy investigation loses meaning if survivors spend years awaiting trial. The authorities must also resist the temptation to convert women's safety into restrictions on women's freedom. The answer to unsafe public spaces cannot be that women should avoid parks after dark, return home earlier, travel only with companions, or otherwise organise their lives around the possibility of male violence. Most importantly, there is a need to challenge the culture of sexual violence and toxic masculinity, enabled by age-old patriarchal traditions.

Season's end

The IMD is conservative when it comes to projecting rainfall deficit

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) issues two forecasts – in April and May – before the monsoon. Both unambiguously pointed to a dry monsoon – confidence boosted by global unanimity that one of the strongest El Niño ever was in the offing – and the consequential question was, ‘How bad?’ It turns out that the IMD's forecast of ‘below normal’ rain (90% to 95% of average) was conservative. This was surprising, given that its models pointed to ‘deficient’ rains (below 90%). On September 30, when India's monsoon tally ended, the IMD announced 759 mm across the country, 87% of the normal 869 mm. El Niño years, when the Central Equatorial Pacific warms and suppresses monsoon rains, test a weather department's mettle because predicting the extent of the shortfall is challenging. It is perplexing why the agency opted for ‘below normal’ rainfall when it could have warned of a ‘deficiency’ and claimed accuracy. As of now the IMD can only claim technical victory because the final number sits within the 4%-5% error window. However, at a disaggregated level, the IMD's struggle with getting magnitude right is far more glaring. June got 65% of its normal, far drier than the 92% forecast. July, expected to be below 94%, ended up with 1% point more rain. August came in at 84% of the LPA, in line with the “below 94%” forecast. September at 92.4% finished a little above the forecast of ‘below 91%.’ The IMD expected a ‘normal’ monsoon in the northeast, which then recorded its driest since 1901, or 26% short. The south peninsula ran 23% short. central and north-west India – tipped to fall below normal – finished close to predictions, driven by ocean conditions and Western disturbances.

Climate change makes this more complicated. Western disturbances, extra-tropical rain-bearing systems, have been bringing more rain to India in the monsoon months, while southern India seems more vulnerable to El Niño-triggered volatility. This is reflected in *kharif* sowing. On July 10, *kharif* sowing trailed last year's by 16%; by early September the gap had narrowed to under 2%. Karnataka has declared drought in well over a 100 taluks and Maharashtra in 265 of 358, though the national deficit of about 12% is below the Centre's 20% threshold for an ‘agricultural drought.’ The IMD expects El Niño to strengthen and bring below normal rain over most of the country from October to December, threatening soil moisture and reservoir recharge. The Cabinet has lifted wheat's support price by ₹25 a quintal and mustard's by ₹413, nudging diversification. Given the consequences of IMD's forecasts, it should improve its sub-regional forecast systems and not shy from being the bearer of ill-news, if needed.

A compilation of articles, on the Editorial and Opinion pages, offering insights into the Mahatma's ideas and legacy

Gandhiji's many ways of understanding ‘genius’

This column is not about Gandhi as a genius (which, with a laugh, he would say he certainly was not) or about the spectacularly original man I believe him to have been. It is about the place of the word ‘genius’ in Gandhi's thought and in his writings.

Why should that common word be picked up from Gandhi's teeming English vocabulary for special attention? Because his use of that valuational word tells us a great deal about his assessment of persons and situations – a matter of interest in itself. And also because we can apply (or not apply) his yardsticks for evaluating persons and happenings in our contemporary times.

There is another non-Gandhi reason as well. Most users of the word do not know that ‘genius’ is a Latin word. Not just a word of Latin origin but a Latin word in its totality – in the way it is spelt, pronounced and meant. English has borrowed ‘genius’ from the language of Virgil, Horace, Ovid without any change whatsoever, somewhat like how C.V. Raman describes the journey of the diamond from its womb under the earth to human hands ‘...absolutely fresh...perfect from nature's crucible.’ And so, reflecting on the word, one might also ponder its travel from one language register to another, admitting some variations in its action.

Here are representative examples culled by Gandhi-researcher Murtaza Gandhi from *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi* (CWMG). Pronounced in both Latin and English identically, as Jee-nee-us, its meaning in classical Latin is ‘divine inner power’. In modern English, when used as a noun, for example ‘the genius S. Ramanujan...’, it denotes a person with exceptional intellectual or creative ability. When used as an adjective, for example, ‘the genius of India...’, it refers to a singular or unique characteristic.

The first encounter

Gandhi uses the word in both senses. His first recorded use of it is as in a skill, a vision, an act of sheer dare. He talks about it as an achievement, not as the description of a person. The reference goes back to 1888, when he was 19 years old and when his English was unpolished. Travelling by the liner *S.S. Clyde* from Bombay to England to start his law studies, he was taken up by the sight of the Suez Canal. Cutting the slender isthmus of the Suez between Asia and Africa to save on journey time by several days, it was a marvel to behold.

He writes in what is now known as his London Diary: “The construction of the Suez Canal I am



Gopalkrishna Gandhi

A teacher who has held administrative, diplomatic and constitutional positions

not able to understand. It is indeed marvellous. I cannot think of the genius of a man who invented it. I don't know how he would have done it.” (CWMG, Vol.01, p.11). The ‘man who invented it’ is, of course, Ferdinand de Lesseps (1805-1894), a French diplomat and entrepreneur, who thought of and made the Canal with the help of two engineers – the Austrian Alois Negrelli and fellow Frenchman Linant de Bellefond.

In this year, 2026, which marks the 70th anniversary of the 1956 Anglo-French-Israeli bombardment of Egypt which aimed to take over the Suez Canal – which Egypt's President Gamal Abdel Nasser had nationalised, – Israel is using more lethal bombs with prodigal abandon in Palestine and Gaza and, with the United States joining the fire-play over Iran, causing the death, among others, of the Supreme Leader of the Iranian state, no less. So, today, we can reflect on Gandhi's marvelling at the genius that went into the making of that oceanic passageway only with anxiety for the future of the area around that marvel.

The dark side

This brings one to a phrase which is twinned to ‘genius’: evil genius (or malignum genium). The earliest known use of that phrase as a concept is in French philosopher Rene Descartes' use of it in his 1641 opus *Meditations on First Philosophy*. He posits in it the existence of a power that is the very opposite of the divine power that actuates ‘genius’ – evil genius, a malignant God or evil power.

By 1893, Barrister M.K. Gandhi was in South Africa and soon became the spokesman and leader of the Indian community there in its strivings for the recognition of its rights and its dignity. Stung by the discriminations and humiliations that Indian South Africans were subjected to, particularly at the hands of the Asiatic Department, we see him use the word not just in its simple sense of a compliment but in its contrary avatar: “There seems to be somewhere in the Asiatic Department of the government an evil genius working through it.” (CWMG, Vol.04, p.26, 23. The Bazaars in The Transvaal) .

‘Evil genius’ occurs in Gandhi's vocabulary again when he is back in India, where he uses it in the context of the Jallianwala Bagh massacre (April 13, 1919) but very pointedly for an individual: “General Dyer has been haltingly blamed, and his evil genius, Sir Michael O'Dwyer, entirely exonerated...” (CWMG, Vol.19, p.339). Just stopping short of using the phrase ‘evil genius’, he invokes the word witheringly with sarcasm, to

describe the British Raj's policy of ‘Divide and Rule’: “But just now I am speaking of the genius of the Government. It has not hesitated to divide Hindus from Muslims in order to be able to retain its hold on us.” (CWMG, Vol.19, p.398, Speech at Nankana Saheb – March 3, 1921).

As a term of praise

The earliest recorded reference by him of a person as a genius in a wholly complimentary sense, is for Lokamanya Bal Gangadhar Tilak who, in 1916, in the town of Belgaum, famously declared (in Marathi) “Swaraj is my birthright and I shall have it.” The ‘Father of Indian Unrest’ had been dead four years but addressing the Indian National Congress' session in the same town of Belgaum in December 1924 as Congress President, Gandhi could not but refer to him and said (in English): He was the genius of swaraj (CWMG, Vol.25, p.508, Concluding Speech at Belgaum Congress, December 27, 1924). Gandhi is doing something very interesting here. He is terming Tilak as a genius of and in something very singular, very specific – swaraj. He is using the term very precisely, very contextually, like he would be if he were to describe Einstein as a genius of the Theory of Relativity.

The next most notable use by him of the word as a personal tribute is for Rabindranath Tagore. Speaking on him in 1931, Gandhi says: “In common with thousands of his countrymen I owe much to one who by his poetic genius and singular purity of life has raised India in the estimation of the world.” (CWMG, Vol.45, p.125, Tribute to Rabindranath Tagore – January 26, 1931).

He was to use the word for him again but again, not as a direct adjective but with a value added: “His creative genius has also given us Santiniketan, Sriniketan and Visvabharati” (CWMG, Vol.84, p.124, Speech at Prayer Meeting, May 8, 1946).

There is one person for whom Gandhi uses the word ‘genius’ without any niche that encases ‘genius’. It is for his friend and almost-preceptor, the young Bombay-based jeweller, poet, Jaina ascetic Rajchandra or Raychandbhai as Gandhi called him: “Kavi Rajchandra was born in a place called Vavania in Kathiawar... His schooling was quite elementary. But he was a genius. He knew Sanskrit, Magadhi and, I believe, Pali” (CWMG, Vol.43, p.98, A Great Seer – March 18, 1930).

Genius can do marvels and do evil. Remembering Gandhi's awareness of that truth is today not a matter of language alone but of life and death.

The Mahatma's unfinished work on the world stage

Writing about Gandhiji's death on his birthday may not be an entirely odd thing, given how he died and how that conflicted with what he stood for. In popular perception, Gandhiji was a tired, old man whose life's work was over when he was assassinated.

In any case, the people he sought to train and transform into compassionate human beings had turned bigoted murderers or condoned bigotry and mass murder during Partition. The last eccentric, going-against-the-grain act they allowed him was fasting in favour of Pakistan. Revisionist history of today seeks to downgrade his role in India's freedom by counterposing Netaji.

But it can be argued that Gandhiji's best years were yet to come even if India had failed him then and now. At 78, Gandhiji was healthy enough to have gone on a village-to-village walk in Noakhali, fasted for three days in Calcutta to stop the rioting before the five-day Delhi fast, and talked about a fast-unto-death to stop the killing of Muslims in Bihar. His health may well have facilitated his shining on the world stage for several more years.

The emergence of a global image

Gandhiji had already ascended the world stage a few decades before in-part due to the rapid growth of print media in the first half 20th century that sought out new and novel stories. Among a non-violent campaign's advantages were that it was carried out in the public domain, transparently – far easier to cover than a clandestine plot. A report on the Dharasana beatings ran in some 1,300 papers worldwide. And photos of Gandhiji, with his dress, or the lack of it, quirks and eccentricities, looked great on newsprint.

Among the many influences Gandhiji had globally was the Black civil rights movement. In America, African-American newspapers were only eager to see parallels and seek inspiration. And it was not symbolic or philosophical but direct and tactical, too. A Harlem ashram and an Ohio ahimsa farm sprang up. Even the



M. Kalyanaraman

Had the Mahatma lived, his message of non-violence might have travelled further and shaped global movements

goat-milking transmuted to America.

Martin Luther King may have been the most famous of civil rights leaders' visits to India but there were many other organisers such as Bayard Rustin and James Lawson who had immersive sojourns in India. A report in *The Hindu* quotes Rustin – he was the organiser of the 1963 March on Washington, at which King delivered the “I Have a Dream” speech – as saying in 1948 that the “Indian non-violent revolution has much to teach us”.

During the Montgomery Bus Boycott, described as the practical kick-off of the civil rights protests led by King, Rustin put his learnings to successful use. He insisted that Montgomery should only be one of many such sites. He ticked off King for having armed guards in his house, saying that Gandhiji would not do that. In a move that caught the attention of many, but which Rustin owed to Gandhiji's methods, he asked that the leaders should go and voluntarily surrender to the police, saying that, yes, they had broken the law, but that it was the right thing to do. Lawson set up a Satyagraha training school in Nashville.

Non-violence on a global scale

Gandhiji did become a global icon, posthumously. For sure, his methods drew from the past. A peaceful march organised by a priest in St. Petersburg was violently put down by the Tsar although it triggered the 1905 revolution. But what was new was that Gandhiji showed that they were duplicable on a mass scale in an organised manner. This was the novelty that caught the imagination of the world later.

Scholars have shown that in the latter half of 20th century, when asymmetries of power solidified, only non-violent campaigns could succeed and did so. East Timor was a sterling example.

Perhaps the best chance that the Palestinians had for Swaraj was in the initial stages of the Intifada. Though known more for the

stone-throwing, the initial protests were largely non-violent but forceful in a Gandhian way. More than all the bombings, assassinations and the plane hijacks engineered by the Palestinians, it could be argued that Intifada 1 forced the Israeli leadership to negotiate and at least on paper commit to a two-state solution eventually though subsequent events upended all that.

It would seem that Gandhiji had planned on playing an active global role after India's Independence. A report in *The Hindu* on March 9, 1948, quotes Horace Alexander as saying that Gandhiji, in England in 1931, had told his friends that when India would be free, he would take part in a world movement for spreading the gospel of non-violence. Another report in August 1947 says that “discussions are now going on between Mahatma Gandhi and some of his American, Indian and European friends” for the world conference.

The conference was held in 1949, a year after his death. International participants discussed setting up an organisation. A.J. Muste wanted to set up a training institute in India. But, without the man himself, Gandhiji became only a soul force, not a physical presence, for non-violent activists across the world.

The Palestine test

If idle speculation could be allowed, a living Gandhiji would have electrified the world that had just gone through a monstrous war and the Holocaust. Instead of becoming just a memorial possibility and vague idealism, non-violence and compassion would have been far more rooted in global discourse.

The best test for Gandhiji would have been Palestine.

If he could make an Englishman ashamed of himself, could he not have made Israeli Jews ashamed of inflicting on Palestinians the suffering Jews had endured for centuries?

kalyanaraman.m@thehindu.co.in

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A balance The new NCERT Class 9 Social Science curriculum significantly reduces the space given to modern European history, replacing chapters on the French and Russian Revolutions. At the same time, it places a much-needed emphasis on Indian history, exploring traditions of governance,	sacred responsibility, and regional resistance and resilience. The inclusion of the <i>Sengol</i> provides an opportunity for students to learn about India's civilisational continuity and political traditions. Since the historical interpretation of the <i>Sengol</i> remains contested (inside pages, October 1), it is vital that	textbooks present competing accounts with adequate evidence. In an age shaped by global change, our education system must seamlessly combine cultural rootedness with rigorous historical inquiry and critical thinking. Sathiyapriya Kumar, Thirukkattupalli, Tamil Nadu	Numbers must work In my experience, several official telephone numbers published on the Tamil Nadu government websites are either ‘switched off, not reachable, or remain unanswered’. These numbers are provided specifically to enable citizens to contact the government offices	concerned for information, clarification or assistance. The official CM Helpline information states that citizens should be able to access grievance services without having to visit a grievance centre and provides multiple channels, including telephone, online portal, mobile application and email to <i>Mudhalvarin</i>	<i>Mugavari</i>. Therefore, there appears to be a clear disconnect between the citizen-friendly services announced by the government and the actual accessibility. Balamarthandan D., Chennai Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.
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